

The Dragon Dance

Based on a Chinese dragon origin myth.

All around her the villagers fought. They fought in the next village, the one after that, the village in the mountains, and the one by the sea. It had always been this way. It had gone on for so long that no one could even remember what they were fighting about.

Liu put her hands over her ears and buried her face into the soft side of her beloved cow Mui-Mui. “That’s enough!” she said to herself,

“This fighting has to stop!”

Tugging on Mui-Mui’s rope, Liu set off to the next village to meet her friend Sun. Mui-Mui mooed loudly to announce their arrival and Sun walked out to meet them, leading his village’s ox behind him. Each of the nine villages had their own sacred animal. It was the children’s job to protect them.

“What’s wrong?” Sun asked Liu when he saw the serious look on her face. Liu explained that the adults were all so busy fighting that they hadn’t noticed that the food stores were running low and winter was coming. Sun agreed that if the adults weren’t going to listen, then the children needed to take action to stop the fighting and bring the villagers together.

With their precious animals in tow, Liu and Sun set off to the next village to meet their friend Chen. Chen met them with his village’s snake draped across his shoulders, and together they chatted all the way to the next village.

By early evening, they had walked through another five villages, collecting five more friends and animals. Exhausted, they walked up into the mountains to the final village. There, they met Mei and her eagle. Mei led all the children into her old barn.

After settling down each animal, the children headed to the fire glinting warmly behind the barn. They talked about the endless fighting and promised that when they grew up they would never fight, but would become one big village and share all the food and work fairly between them.

As the last child joined hands, a great whoosh swept them up and spun them around. Out of the barn, in a clap of thunder, swooped a most extraordinary creature.

